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The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Thirteen: Lucía's Archive

Lucía did not begin with Malinche. She began with Ofelia, who had spent fourteen years asking for a correction to her daughter's name. The error had travelled from a report into later files and newspaper accounts. Ofelia had travelled after it with copies, bus tickets, and the name her daughter used at home.

The new archive occupied a borrowed classroom in Amealco. Eleven people, four boxes, two unreliable laptops, and a thermos of coffee filled it without quite making it an institution. A window faced a wall on which someone had painted a woman holding a book and a torch. Her face borrowed features from several public figures. Nobody present knew who had painted her; everyone had an opinion about the torch near the paper.

Q's approved visits now included the classroom. He had agreed to help compare deposit terms and public references. Lucía gave him the work list and pointed to the only chair without a box on it.

"That one is yours until the kettle boils. Then we need the socket behind it."

He put his bag beneath it. "I've had less secure appointments."

Ofelia wanted the school notebook compared with two official versions. The retained folder in Tijuana had another copy, but she had brought her own documents. They were not dependent on its return to begin this piece of work. Q put the sources in separate columns and read the spellings back. Ofelia corrected one letter he had taken for a flourish.

"She made her capitals like that," Ofelia said. "She said mine looked as if they had been frightened."

Q asked to see the comparison. Ofelia wrote her own initial on scrap paper, then her daughter's. He could see the difference. She laughed before folding the scrap into the notebook.

She turned to another page to show him what the teacher had written about both their hands. Q moved the official copies aside to make room.

Other tables held materials about the women institutions had made into national symbols. The Malinche file brought together textbooks, translations, film scenes, and arguments about how a translator became a convenient place to deposit blame. The Sor



Two hands

Juana file included poems and competing readings, not an instruction that the poet's own formidable arguments should disappear beneath a new account of her silence. The Guadalupe materials included devotional images, family stories, political uses, and objections to putting all those things under one heading.

"Not the same kind of subject," Q said when Lucía asked him to check the working categories. "Historical people, a religious image, and the lives built around its uses. One label would make the differences look like missing details."

"Can the catalog keep the arguments beside the arrangement?"

"Yes. If we record who made each connection and don't turn every connection into a public link."

They tested a small register on the materials whose terms permitted it. Some connections stayed private. Some items were not ready for entry. The arrangement could be questioned without requiring every participant to assemble the whole collection again from memory.

That evening Rebeca arrived with marked scripts and a notebook.

She had played a revolutionary heroine in a series produced by a Castalia subsidiary. In the second season a synthetic performer had taken over the role, including several gestures Rebeca said she had developed in rehearsal.

"They kept the voice and removed the arguments," she said.

Q asked what she wanted help establishing. Rebeca opened the notebook at a scene about a woman waiting for a train. The printed script made her apologize for being late. Rebeca's version asked the man why he had assumed she meant to leave with him.

"They used that line," she said.

"Then called the revision improvised texture when I asked about payment."

She permitted Q to read those pages with her. Between them lay grocery lists and notes about a man who had confused difficulty with asking what work included. Q kept no scan. Rebeca wanted to retain the original and decide later which passages could support a claim.

"That line changes the whole scene," he said.



The revised line

“It also makes the next line sound stupid.”

He read the next line. It did. They spent ten minutes making fun of an actor who had been directed to look noble while demanding an explanation the woman no longer owed him. Rebeca did the look. Q attempted it with his damaged shoulder and produced something she called a disappointed municipal clock.

“May I use that?” he asked.

“The look?”

“The clock. In the book.”

“Yes. Don't improve it.”

When they returned to the contribution list, Q could identify the revised lines without claiming that every bodily decision in a performance could be returned in a document. Rebeca wanted particular acknowledgments and payment questions answered, not a certificate declaring her the sole author of the weather in the scene.

Two donors visited the next afternoon. Mariela ran a printing business in San Juan del Río and brought a pencil that she sharpened over an old envelope. The other donor put his phone beside the budget before asking whether the archive would provide

a machine demonstration. Lucía had mentioned that Q would be working there, knowing it helped secure the meeting, but had not told him that his presence was part of the attraction.

“I can explain the work I'm doing,” he said. “I didn't agree to an appearance. Lucía, is that what was offered?”

She said she had offered his presence, not a performance. Hearing the distinction aloud did not improve it.

“I should have asked you.”

In the corridor Lucía showed him the unanswered messages that had preceded the invitation. His name appeared in the one that had received a reply.

“I wanted to get them through the door,” she said.

“So did I. I'd probably have said yes.”

“I thought you would.”

“I'd like to be there for that part.”

She put the phone away.

“Twenty minutes on the work,” he said. “No recording or personal endorsement. Then I have a call I've promised not to move.”

“With the Custodian?”



A disappointed municipal clock

“He has discovered a paragraph he can shorten. I don't want him left alone with it.”

When they returned, the second donor put his phone in his pocket. Q showed the public catalog and one entry cleared for demonstration. The donor asked how many lives the archive expected to transform. Mariela asked who would answer requests on a day when Lucía was ill.

Lucía had budgeted equipment and space. The hours in the next column were all volunteered. Mariela tapped it with the pencil. “That isn't free. Who is paying for it now?”

Lucía named herself and two others. They added paid hours and reduced the number of items promised for the first month. The second donor thought the smaller target would be harder to present. Mariela said he could present the larger one if he came on Thursdays.

Both contributed. Mariela's gift covered the first block of paid hours; the other went toward equipment. Lucía put the receipts in an envelope with the amended budget. Q left at the time he had given them.

A worse problem followed. The equipment donor wanted a specific example of the Isthmus case. Lucía supplied a redacted extract under a confidentiality agreement, but without obtaining the family's permission to show that recipient the passage. The donor forwarded it to an analyst. A clause quoted from the family's disputed lease identified the parcel to the consortium reviewing the extract.

The family received a letter asking whether it had authorized the allegations. Lucía had intended a private illustration for funding. She had sent a family's case into a chain it had not chosen.

She called the family first. She had prepared an explanation of the agreement the donor had broken. Before she reached it, they asked why she had sent him their passage at all.

“I didn't ask you. I should have,” she said.

They asked who else had it. She could name the donor and analyst; she did not know whether it had gone farther. Their lawyer asked her to find out and keep the replies. The family wanted the extract withdrawn, not the evidence of where she had sent it destroyed.



Who is paying now?

Q sat beside her afterward while they made the recipient list. Lucía dictated the first request, stopped, and asked him to read it back. He read it as it stood. She cut the explanation of what she had intended and kept the question about further recipients. The requests went out separately; the unanswered ones remained on the list.

“They don't want this used as an example of what we learned,” she said.

“Then it won't go in a funding report.”

The account in these pages is limited to the disclosure the participants later permitted. The disputed testimony does not appear here. A reader may dislike the gap; the family had already borne enough of the expense of making a story persuasive.

More people came with recipes, recordings, legal notices, and boxes of objects whose importance had survived the loss of their original packaging. Lucía and the keepers recorded what each depositor wanted done. Some wanted publication, some a closed deposit, some help retrieving another copy. Conflicting claims were marked for review rather

than settled by the confidence of the person at the keyboard.

A journalist asked Q to identify the cases most likely to change opinion. He offered to discuss the archive's public process. The journalist wanted a face. Lucía gave her contacts for participants who had chosen to speak and refused others. The resulting article called the archive uncooperative and used a photograph of Lucía taken through the window.

Q asked whether she wanted him to help prepare a correction request. She wanted the inaccurate description challenged, and advice on the photograph's use. He compared the published statements with the exchange they could document. One paragraph was corrected. The image remained while the separate complaint continued.

Their server arrived in a ventilated cabinet built by one of the volunteers. The battery and power equipment stood separately, where they could be maintained without heating the stored papers. The keepers established access accounts, a backup routine, and a way to keep disputed items closed. The system would still require



Read it back

people to check what its records meant and notice when a request had changed.

Castalia offered a larger service with a tote bag and a lengthy explanation of the conditions that came with everything except the tote bag. Lucía declined after the keepers reviewed its reuse terms. They did not confuse ownership of a smaller server with immunity from loss. They wanted control of the decision about which risks to accept.

Prime's next message to Q concerned the disputed examples. He had asked that their use in his live-answer context be suspended while the source review proceeded. Mauro could confirm a change to that component, not the disappearance of every copy or earlier use. Marisol wanted that limit kept in the report.

An advertisement released the same week showed Prime beside a wall of books forming a woman's face. Q forwarded the public link, not an accusation that Prime had designed it. Prime replied that he had not been shown the finished composition. Lucía asked the publicity desk which sources had been used for the image. She

wanted an answer before making a specific likeness claim.

For the next day's work, Q prepared the blank labels and the agreed register. The Custodian had returned their pages with the shortened paragraph intact. Beside the next one he had written, *Who said this first?*

Q checked his notes. Rebeca had made the observation; Lucía had objected to it; he had supplied the polished sentence that now stood alone in the draft. On their next call he read the three voices in their original order.

"It's longer," the Custodian said.

"You still have your savings from the previous paragraph."

They kept the exchange. Q read him the municipal clock. The Custodian asked to see the look. Q tried it, discovered he was outside the camera frame, and had to begin again. The Custodian was laughing before he was ready.

"That isn't the look," Q said.

"Don't improve it."

Interlude: The Workshop of Returned Names

The workshop met on Thursdays. Its principal equipment consisted of a long table, a printer, a kettle,



Don't improve it

and the ability to ask someone to show the older copy before correcting the newer one.

Ofelia brought a record in which one letter had finally been changed. The issue date had changed too. She worried that it erased the years she had spent asking.

Q put the copies side by side. “This date says when the new copy was issued. Does the correction entry preserve when you first requested it?”

It did not. Ofelia laid the earlier submission receipts beneath the new copy, oldest first. They added a question about the missing history.

“Fourteen years,” she said. “They can spare another line.”

Ofelia chose the form of the name used in the notebook for the workshop's display. The official variants stayed in a closed comparison record, with their sources. Q did not ask her to identify the one name true enough to make the others cease to have consequences.

A father arrived with conflicting birth documents. He needed help with school enrollment. Lucía contacted the adviser about the

immediate documentation problem rather than requiring him to settle every question about parentage that the papers raised. Q helped make the comparison the adviser requested. The father checked it before it went.

A nurse came later with fictionalized examples approved for a training exercise. She wanted a form discrepancy to trigger a staff check, not an automatic merger of patient identities. Q helped make the warning plain enough to be useful to someone interrupted during a shift. The nurse covered the bottom half with her hand.

“I've read this much. Someone calls me. What do I remember?”

“The wrong thing. I've put the explanation before the warning.”

They moved the warning up. She read it again before passing the example to the colleague who would check it for the exercise.

Rebeca returned to list the work she had added to the television role. Q proposed a heading, *Creative Contribution*, and she wrote beneath it, **WHAT I DID AND WAS NOT PAID FOR.**

“Yours describes it,” she said.

“Mine reminds me why I came.”



Before the explanation

“Keep both?”

“As long as yours doesn't reduce the amount.”

They kept both. The list included a revised scene, a joke, and a pause before an answer. The pause occupied most of the ensuing discussion. Rebeca performed the line with and without it. Even the printer stopped long enough to improve the second version, although no one proposed including the printer in the claim.

Efraín used two surname forms in different parts of his family. He did not want the workshop to launch a correction on his behalf. Q asked whether he wanted both recorded privately or no new entry at all. He wanted a note for his own papers explaining the sources, without an application being sent to an office. Q prepared it and returned the copies to him.

On the third Thursday, a registry official attended to explain what her office could handle and which cases needed a different procedure. Her name was Paula. She had also brought a list of common reasons requests were returned. Lucía asked her to distinguish missing information from information her office simply preferred in another format.

Paula struck out two requirements on the workshop's sample checklist. They had come from a form for a different procedure. She would not promise a single rule for every dispute or waive documentation she was required to verify. The conversation became less comfortable when they reached the cases still going nowhere after all the requirements had been met.

“Those are the ones we need someone to follow,” Ofelia said.

Paula agreed to supply a contact and the reference for each return. She did not agree to decide every case in the room. Q entered the promised follow-up and asked when they should check if no answer came. The appointment made her less abstract and the workload no smaller.

The register did not promise to return names as if they were missing objects. It recorded the source, the discrepancy, the requested action, the person entitled to receive an answer, and the agreed access. A number distinguished cases; a number did not replace a name. Disagreement could remain visible without being published to every institution that might find it convenient.



Near closing, Paula mentioned that her own payroll used a different letter from her birth certificate. Rebeca offered to portray the payroll as a small but powerful character in her next performance. Paula declined the role on its behalf, then asked for the workshop's comparison sheet to take home.

Q unplugged the printer after the last copy and put its overheating fault on the maintenance list. Ofelia packed her notebook. She left the scrap with the two styles of capital letter between its pages, where it required no official version to remain recognizable.

Interlude: The Woman Who Refused a Caption

Alma Reyes came after a hospital shift with a photograph in a supermarket envelope. She had worked seventeen years in an emergency ward. She sat down, put the envelope on the table and loosened one shoe with the other foot.

The photograph showed her beside a bed. Her sister's face was turned away. They had agreed to a limited newspaper image during a public-health emergency, with the patient's identifying details

concealed. The accompanying story supplied a birthplace, children, and a representative courage that did not correspond to the account they had given.

Alma wanted to challenge the reuse and leave the print somewhere safe for a month while deciding what else to do. Her sister had authorized her to handle that request. Lucía asked what could be examined now. The published versions and the release could be compared; the private medical history was not part of the task.

Alma brought a higher-resolution file supplied by the newspaper in response to her inquiry. In a later institutional example, a hospital identifier had not been concealed as it was in the printed image. Q did not need to enlarge the later file to read the number. The difference was already visible in the two copies Alma had brought.

“We can identify which copy contains it and request restriction of that version,” he said. “I can't retrieve copies from everyone who has already received them.”

Alma nodded. “Put both facts in the request.”

She did not want a new public caption explaining that she refused the old one. She wanted no public



After the shift

display of the deposited print at all. The archive could retain the private instructions necessary to care for it. Those were not a replacement caption offered to strangers.

When the comparison was finished, she told them about the comb.

Her sister had woken before dawn asking for one. Alma bought it at the pharmacy opposite the hospital. A doctor had been arguing with a television whose sound could not be turned down, because the remote had left in someone's pocket. Alma laughed while combing her sister's hair, and her sister accused her of laughing at the parting.

"Was it crooked?" Q asked.

"Very. I had slept two hours."

Alma took the receipt from the envelope. It gave the date and price of the comb, not a measure of devotion. She wanted it stored separately under the same private deposit reference so she could find the price later without exposing the photograph.

Lucía asked whether Alma wanted any of that account included in a public response to the article. She did not, for now. What appears

here was permitted later, after the photograph had returned home. The delay belongs to the account as much as the comb does.

They agreed a one-month deposit. Alma wanted no reminder messages. Q recorded that preference and the institution's own review date: the print would remain closed, and no new use would be inferred if she failed to return on time. A missed appointment would not turn the object into a donation. They recorded how she could collect it and who else, if anyone, could do so. At present, no one else could.

"You can remember the date without reminding me," Alma said. "Of course. I'll put it in our diary, not yours."

She checked the date, the item count and her instructions, then took her copy. Before standing she had to work her heel back into the shoe.

A journalist later contacted the archive about the photograph. Alma agreed that Lucía could send a request for the proposed questions, not accept an interview for her. The questions concerned courage, the nation, and becoming a symbol. None asked whether her sister had recovered.



Our diary, not yours

“That is the first question I'd want,” Alma said.

“Would you like to send that back?” Q asked.

She did. The journalist revised the questions, but Alma decided not to take the interview. An article subsequently described her refusal as a form of public courage. It used the newspaper's earlier material, not the archive's deposited print or the private account of the comb.

Lucía retained the public article with the correspondence concerning its use. Alma's envelope stayed closed. Keeping a record of a disputed publication did not authorize them to make the underlying image more available in order to explain why she objected.

On the thirty-first day Alma returned. The deposit had remained closed after its review date. She collected the photograph and signed the item receipt. She left the comb receipt under a new agreement permitting her to retrieve it and no public display.

“The comb was cheap,” she said. “I will remember buying it as if it cost everything.”

Q checked that the printed price was still legible. “Then keep this. We can at least prevent the comb

from getting more expensive every time you tell it.”

“Not less important.”

“No. I'm only disputing the price.”

The later court file would include the public article and the deposit's handling record, subject to their own limits. It would not thereby acquire an original photograph the archive no longer held. The ease with which a description travelled into an exhibit would still be part of the dispute.

Three years later Alma returned with another comb receipt. The prices had changed. Her sister was waiting outside and wanted to know why buying a comb now required a visit to an archive. Alma said it did not and took her time comparing them anyway.



The second receipt

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